

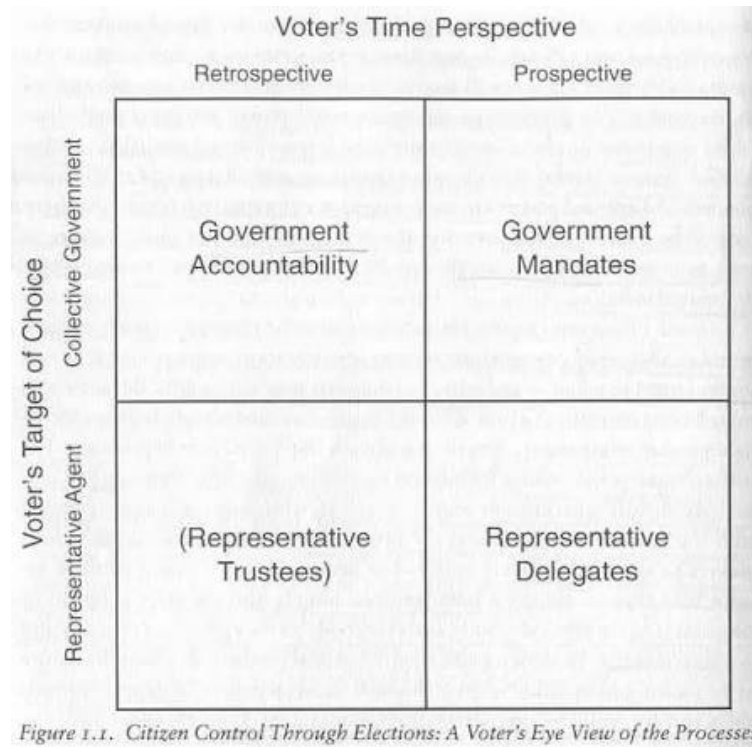
Powell 2000 RG Notes

Powell, G. Bingham Jr. *Elections as Instruments of Democracy: Majoritarian and Proportional Visions*.
New Haven: Yale University Press, 2000.

1 Main Idea

2 General Notes

- Primary distinction between democratic approaches: *control* over policymakers or *influence* over policy. Each corresponds to a certain “grand vision” of electoral accountability:
 - Majoritarian: The majority should have a near-absolute right to rule, and policy should proceed in accordance with the majority’s wishes. Focuses on a relationship of power between voters and their elected officials, whereby voters become “principals” who seek to either reward or control their representatives. Consistent with the “control” narrative. Centralization of power follows from this, and the primary role of the citizen is to enforce consequences during elections.
 - Proportionalism: The will of each group should be reflected in policy in accordance with the relative size of that group. Focuses on a relationship of influence whereby policy is swayed in a degree proportionate to the relative power of that group, subsequently protecting minority welfare at the expense of direct control over the political system. Consistent with the “influence” narrative. Considers elections to be clumsy/noisy signals, and prioritizes universal input without giving an oversized benefit to the majority group
- Voters’ roles can be roughly perceived as either retrospective or prospective. If retrospective, more aligned with majoritarianism: the voter either punishes or rewards incumbents with their vote (or lack thereof), based on the observed quality of their tenure. If prospective, more aligned with proportionalism: the voter seeks credible commitments from candidates and has some expectation of their performance.



- The result of this broader differentiation is two metrics of electoral success: (1) responsiveness to elections in choosing policymakers, and (2) representational congruence between the policymakers' positions and the citizens' preferences. Majoritarianism *should* do better with (1), and proportionalism better with (2).
- Election rules in SMDP systems generally limit the number of seats and subsequent equilibria features limited numbers of viable candidates based off of those seats (see Duverger). This can create a significant disproportion in representation amongst majoritarian systems: a 49% share may ultimately be entirely unrepresented in a legislature. High effective thresholds – explicit or systemic vote share requirements in order for a party to gain representation – benefit a majoritarian perspective. As the effective threshold increases, the expected vote-seat disproportionality increases as well.
- “If the decision rules encourage or require the government parties to negotiate with independent groups in the assembly, especially those representing voters who supported different parties, I want to characterize them as closer to the proportional vision. If the decision rules encourage the government parties to control the executive and the assembly without check or division, I characterize them as majoritarian.”
- “Influence of the opposition” from Strom – largely based on the role and importance of committees. Presence is important, of course, but further considerations: do the committees have policymaking power? Is there any veto opportunity for minority parties within committees? Are the committees highly specialized such that mainstream ideological backgrounds of certain parties can be effectively cast aside? Committees as a primary metric of decentralization

- Though constitutional design and legislative rules can change over time, their change in democracies is usually not particularly drastic or quick, for a number of reasons including institutional safeguards. But, an additional – and potentially strongest – consideration: an incumbent usually has won office through some means of benefitting from the system in place, and therefore has minimal incentive to change it. This is a more self-serving equilibrium outcome than a Dahl “trust in the opposition” framework, and rather suggests tautologically that the system usually has worked for whoever is currently in power.
- A core component of retrospective voting requires that the citizens are able to perceive who should be held accountable for what decisions. Though this may be obvious in some more direct settings – and par

3 Important Specific Factual Claims

- Making retrospective judgments requires some clarity about specifically *who* made *what* judgments. Requires both some degree of transparency and a sense of consistency from amongst the citizens, who in turn need to accurately perceive the dynamic at hand. This adds an additional dynamic to be considered: clarity of responsibility
- Focuses on two alternative methods of connection between citizen preferences and the formation of policy coalitions (and subsequently policy): differentiating factor is whether or not a voter’s vote is sufficient to fully express their preferences. This may not be the case precisely because voters are presented with an exclusive menu, rather than empowered to fully express their specific preferences over a continuous domain.
- Possible veto institutions to restrict a national assembly’s power:
 1. Independent executives (main example is USA)
 2. Separate legislative chamber with independent selection base and veto powers
 3. Federal systems: regional checks on centralized power
 4. Judicial review (think Vanberg) – court system (usually independent) has some oversight over legislative process
- Majoritarianism provides a degree of quantitative stability in election result shifts: a tiny change in vote margin is unlikely to result in a regime change in a majoritarian system, while a proportionalist system may be much more volatile to such changes

4 Connections

- Figure 1.2 (pg. 15) should link directly to Dahl: begin with citizen preferences/beliefs, flow to policy
- Many references to (and in agreement with) Lijphart 1984, who differentiates two approaches to democratic government: either the government should be responsive to

the majority (Westminster approach), or should be responsive to “as many people as possible.”

5 My Critiques

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